So, what can be done to prevent or minimise man-elephant conflict? India now has 33 elephant reserves which overlap with national parks and sanctuaries; 150 jumbo corridors have also been ground-validated in 15 states. Both the Centre and the state governments have been working on mitigatory measures, but the slide continues. Forest department officials are mostly of the view that unless elephant habitats are kept sacrosanct, there is little that can be done; eventually, the jumbos will come out in search of food. Three years ago, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) identified conflict hotspots, set up rapid response teams and issued an advisory to states on reducing man-animal conflict. One suggestion to farmers in conflict areas: switch to cash crops which elephants find inedible.

In states like West Bengal, which saw 436 human casualties in the past five years, rapid response teams (RRTs), a bulk SMS system to inform locals, the police and others of the presence of wild elephants, and deploying of specialised vehicles called 'Airawats' are some of the measures being taken in conflict zones. Many states have also been erecting solar power fencing along vulnerable village boundaries but, again, elephants in more than a few zones have learnt how to bypass them.

MP lost its elephant habitats to Chhattisgarh when it was carved out of the state in 2000, and consequently did not have any elephants left in its forests. It was in 2018 that the first jumbos came to Bandhavgarh from Chhattisgarh, driven out by mining and clearing of forests in the neighbouring state. The state may find ways to prevent kodo millet poisoning in the future, but preventing retribution killings of elephants has to be a priority. Till around three decades ago, a large number of tigers were being lost to retribution by cattle owners who would often poison the kills for which the tigers would return. Handsome compensation, as much as Rs 40,000 per animal, helped considerably in reducing tiger mortality.

Experts suggest a similar scheme for crop losses and such. But compensation for crop damage has not been as prompt or handsome so far. "Farmers run from pillar to post after monkeys or wild boar raid their crops. Revenue officials often undervalue losses, with the result that farmers are denied compensation. This leads to anger and retribution killing," says a senior forest official in MP, adding that crop compensation in high man-animal conflict areas should be left to their department.

On November 3, CM Yadav announced the setting up of a state-level elephant task force, claiming that MP was new to the jumbo phenomenon. The state is also sending forest staff to Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu to study elephant behaviour and mitigation measures. Hopefully, the experience of other states will help MP avert tragedy in its midst. ■

–with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

MAN VS ANIMAL

- **Ten of 40 elephants in Bandhavgarh sanctuary die of poisoning after gorging on infected kodo millet**
- **Deliberate act or not, the incident once again highlights rising incidents of man-elephant conflict**
- **Three days after the incident, two men trampled to death and one injured inside the sanctuary**
- **Jumbos have returned only recently to MP after many years**

RAJASTHAN

A LITMUS TEST FOR BHAJAN SHARMA

By Rohit Parihar

Just 11 months into power, and the Rajasthan chief minister faces yet another challenge at the hustings. At stake are seven of the state's 200 assembly seats–Jhunjhunu, Dausa, Deoli-Uniara, Khinvsar, Chorasi, Ramgarh and Salumber–that go to bypolls on November 13. When the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party's Lok Sabha seat tally slid in Rajasthan from 24 to 14 amid a near-10 percentage point drop in vote share this June, Sharma escaped much of the criticism. For, he had been at the helm for just three months when the model code of conduct kicked in and was involved neither in candidate selection nor in chalking out strategy. This time, however, a lot of the onus shifts to him.

Even though the BJP announced six of its seven candidates when Sharma was on a tour of Germany and the UK to invite potential investors to the Rising Rajasthan Global Investment Summit scheduled in December, he has been leading the campaign since his return on October 20.

THE ODDS ARE NOT EASY FOR SHARMA. FOUR OF THE SEVEN SEATS BOUND FOR BYPOLLS HAVE BEEN VOTING CONGRESS OF LATE. TWO ARE POCKET BOROUGHS OF SMALL PARTIES RLP AND BAP